

CASE-04

# When the buyer's real fear is fraud, trust is the product.

An end-to-end specification for an antiques auction marketplace — personas, user stories with acceptance criteria and corner cases, wireframes, and the login flow.

SELF-DIRECTED CASE STUDY

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Product spec · Personas · User stories & corner cases

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# Four sides, not two.

Collectors, casual sellers, professional dealers and appraisers each define success differently, and a marketplace that optimises for one of them quietly breaks for the others.

The collector's blocking fear is buying a counterfeit. The casual seller's is not knowing what an inherited object is worth. **Neither of those is solved by a bidding engine** — which is the part everyone builds first.

The incumbents make the point: one does live auctions well but abandons beginners; the other has reach and no antiques focus at all, which dilutes the category experience.

Who it serves

BUY SIDE

**Collectors ·  
casual buyers**

SELL SIDE

**Casual sellers ·  
dealers**

THIRD SIDE

**Appraisers**

# What ships in the first release?

An auction marketplace has an obvious core. Building only that core is the mistake.

## SHIP THE AUCTION FIRST

Bidding is the visible heart of the product, and it's what a marketplace is expected to look like on day one.

## SHIP TRUST WITH IT

Verification, buyer protection, secure payment. Without them the auction has nothing anyone is willing to bid on.

So the MVP stayed deliberately thin on features and unusually thick on guarantees: registration, listing, search, simple bidding, payments and a seller dashboard — with the **authenticity path specified alongside them**, not after.

# What I specified, and why.

## 1 • The corner cases, not just the happy path

Corrupt uploads, identical maximum bids, a winner whose payment fails, unreadable appraisal documents, a seller disputing a rejection — each with defined system behaviour.

## 2 • Admin approval before any item goes live

A 48-hour service level, notification on delay, and a stated reason on every rejection — so the gate is a promise to sellers rather than a black box.

## 3 • Authenticity made visible on the listing

A digital badge and a downloadable certificate. Verification that a buyer can't see does nothing for the buyer's confidence.

## 4 • A thin MVP with a sequenced roadmap

Appraisals and dealer analytics in the second quarter, mobile in the third. Trust primitives first, sophistication after.

# I put admin approval in front of every single listing, knowing it caps supply growth.

Manual review is the enemy of marketplace liquidity, and a reviewer is a bottleneck you have to pay for. In most categories I would fight to remove it.

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What I took from it

In a marketplace where the buyer's core fear is being defrauded, a slower supply pipeline isn't friction — it's the value proposition. Growth that erodes trust in this category doesn't compound. It unwinds.

Happy to talk through the thinking —  
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